

Recognize it

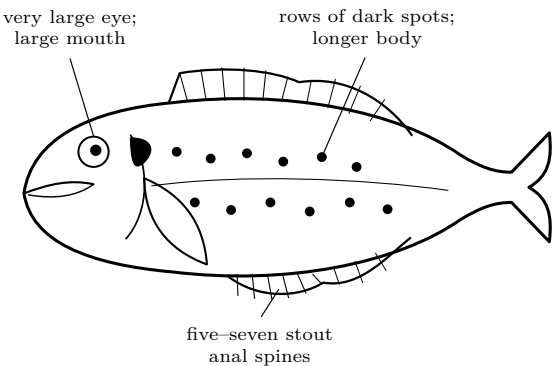
Stocky olive sunfish with red eye and rows of dark side spots.

Body	More elongate than bluegill; five to seven anal spines.
Mouth/fins	Mouth reaches beneath eye; continuous dorsal with strong spines.
Confusion	Warmouth has three anal spines and radiating dark cheek lines.

Lake role

Where it belongs Rock, wood, docks, shade, and firm transitions.
Food and season Crayfish, insects, and small fish; often close to bottom or hard cover.

Identification plate



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test rocky points, hard-bottom breaks, and shade where accessible.
North	Test wood, riprap, narrows, and firm spots beside weeds.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Small jig.** Hop a compact plastic or hair jig through rock; pause in gaps.
- 2. **Live-bait float.** Suspend worm or small minnow beside cover, not inside the snag.
- 3. **Stop rule.** If only tiny fish bite, move to the next deeper hard edge.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Beware dorsal and anal spines; wet hands and cradle the fish.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; rock/yellow/white bass daily bag unlimited on both lake pages.
Kitchen choice	Keep thicker mid-size fish that yield usable fillets; stop at the planned meal despite no daily limit.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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